LEAD NOW FOUNDATION

Building Leaders. Transforming Communities.

Fraud, Bribery and Conflict of Interest Policy

2026 Edition · Version 1.0

Trust is the foundation of everything we do with young people, communities and funders. This policy sets out how we protect it — by being open about our interests, refusing every bribe, and acting quickly when something goes wrong.

Lead Now Foundation (registered as LeadNow Foundation)
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Document control

Item	Detail
Document	Lead Now Foundation Fraud, Bribery and Conflict of Interest Policy
Version	1.0 (2026 Edition)
Adapted from	Student Partnership Worldwide India Project Trust (SPWIPT) Fraud & Bribery Policy, 2021
Owner	Chief Executive Officer (CEO)
Approved by	Board of Directors, Lead Now Foundation
Date of approval	_____
Next review	Annually, or after a significant change in operations or a significant incident
Related documents	Human Resource Manual 2026 (Sections 6, 9 and 10); Finance Policy and Procedures 2026; Safeguarding Policy 2026; Code of Conduct

If you suspect fraud or bribery

Situation	What to do
You are offered or asked for a bribe	Say no and make our position clear. Write down what happened as soon as you can, and report it to your Performance Manager or the CEO the same day.
You suspect fraud or a financial irregularity	Report it to your Performance Manager, verbally and then in writing. Do not investigate it yourself or confront the person.
You are not comfortable using your reporting line	Report to the CEO, or confidentially to **info@leadnowfoundation.org** (monitored by the Program Lead).
The concern involves the CEO	Report directly to the **Chair of the Board of Directors**.
Your safety is at immediate risk	Your safety comes first (Section 5.6). Report afterwards.

Contents

1. Introduction 4
1.1 Purpose 4
1.2 Scope 4
1.3 Our commitment 4
2. Key Definitions 5
3. Conflicts of Interest 7
3.1 Types of conflict 7
3.2 Examples 7
3.3 How to declare 8
3.4 Who reviews a declaration 8
3.5 Register of interests 8
4. Fraud and Irregularities 9
4.1 Examples of fraud 9
4.2 Other irregularities 9
4.3 Fraud against us from outside 9
5. Bribery and Corruption 10
5.1 The law 10
5.2 Examples of bribery 10
5.3 Facilitation payments 10
5.4 Gifts and hospitality 11
5.5 Political and charitable donations 11
5.6 When your safety is at risk 11
6. Roles and Responsibilities 12
7. Prevention 13
7.1 Leadership from the top 13
7.2 Risk assessment 13
7.3 Due diligence 13
7.4 Controls that prevent fraud 14
7.5 Communication and training 14
8. Reporting Concerns 15
8.1 If you are offered or asked for a bribe 15
8.2 How to report 15
8.3 Protection for people who report 15
8.4 Matters that do not need reporting 16
9. Responding to Incidents 17
9.1 Our response, step by step 17
9.2 Legal and regulatory reporting 18
9.3 Incident register 18
10. Monitoring and Review 18
Appendix A: Declaration of Interests 19
Appendix B: Gifts and Hospitality Register 20
Appendix C: Fraud and Bribery Incident Report 21
Appendix D: Acknowledgement 22

1. Introduction

1.1 Purpose

Lead Now Foundation exists to show what young people can do when they are trusted with leadership and resources. Every rupee we hold was entrusted to us by funders and communities for that purpose. Fraud, bribery and undeclared conflicts of interest betray that trust — and undermine the case that youth-led organisations can be trusted at all.

This policy sets out how we:

- Identify, declare and manage conflicts of interest (Section 3).
- Prevent, detect and respond to fraud and other irregularities (Section 4).
- Refuse and report bribery and corruption in every form (Section 5).
- Respond fairly, transparently and decisively when something goes wrong (Section 9).

1.2 Scope

This policy applies to everyone who works with or on behalf of Lead Now Foundation: staff, members of the Board of Directors, young leaders, volunteers, interns and consultants. Its expectations also apply to partners, suppliers and agents acting on our behalf, through our contracts and partnership agreements.

This policy is the full statement of our position. Sections 9 and 10 of the Human Resource Manual summarise it, and the Finance Policy and Procedures set out the financial controls that put it into practice. Where Indian law sets a higher standard, the law prevails.

1.3 Our commitment

Policy

Lead Now Foundation has **zero tolerance** for fraud, bribery and corruption, by anyone acting on its behalf.

We will be open about our interests, transparent when incidents occur, and fair to everyone involved in investigating them.

No one will suffer any detriment for refusing to pay a bribe, or for raising a concern in good faith — even if the concern turns out to be mistaken, or refusing a bribe costs us an opportunity.

Our values shape how we live this commitment:

Value	What it means here
Youth Agency	We model the integrity we want young leaders to carry into the institutions they will lead.

Value	What it means here
Equity	Our rules apply equally to everyone — the CEO and Board as much as a new volunteer.
Collaboration	We hold partners and suppliers to the same standards we hold ourselves, and help them meet them.
Dignity	We treat people raising concerns, and people under investigation, with fairness and respect. Everyone is presumed innocent until the facts are established.
Systems Thinking	We fix the weaknesses that allowed an incident to happen, not just the incident itself.

2. Key Definitions

Term	Meaning
Fraud	Any intentional act of deception — including falsifying or concealing records, or misrepresenting facts — carried out by anyone inside or outside the organisation to obtain an advantage, avoid an obligation, or cause a loss to Lead Now Foundation or others.
Irregularity	Unauthorised use of the organisation's resources for private benefit, even where there is no intention to deceive — for example, "borrowing" from petty cash.
Bribery	Offering, promising, giving, requesting, agreeing to receive or accepting money, a gift or any other advantage, directly or through someone else, to induce or reward improper conduct or a breach of trust.
Corruption	The abuse of entrusted power or position for private gain.
Facilitation payment	A small unofficial payment to an official to speed up, or secure, a routine action they are already obliged to perform. Facilitation payments are bribes.
Conflict of interest	A situation in which personal, family, professional or financial interests may affect — or could appear to others to affect — someone's objectivity or fairness in their work for Lead Now Foundation.

Term	Meaning
Close family	Family members or members of the same household who might influence, or be influenced by, the person in their dealings with Lead Now Foundation. This normally includes a spouse or partner, parent, child, sibling, and the spouse or partner of any of these. The list is not exhaustive.

3. Conflicts of Interest

Lead Now Foundation aims to uphold high ethical standards and to make every decision — about people, money and partnerships — on its merits. Transparency and disclosure are how we achieve this. When interests are declared openly, conflicts can be identified and managed before they cause harm, and the credibility of our programmes and decisions is protected.

> **Policy**
>
> Everyone covered by this policy must declare any personal, family, professional or financial interest that could give rise to a real, potential or perceived conflict of interest.
>
> Anyone with a conflict of interest in a decision must declare it and take no part in that decision.
>
> Failure to declare a conflict of interest is a breach of this policy.

3.1 Types of conflict

- **Real:** a current interest that may compromise someone's work — for example, a staff member whose relative owns a supplier we are considering.
- **Potential:** an interest that can be foreseen to affect someone's work in future, but has not yet arisen — for example, a staff member planning to take on paid work outside the organisation.
- **Perceived:** a situation where others (funders, partners, colleagues, communities) could reasonably believe there is a conflict, even if there is none. Declaring openly is the best way to manage perceptions.

Declare interests even if you do not believe there is a conflict. If in doubt, declare.

3.2 Examples

As a guide only, conflicts of interest could include situations where a staff member or director:

- Has a close family member working for Lead Now Foundation, especially in the same reporting line.
- Is related to, or has a financial interest in, an existing or potential supplier, partner or grantee.
- Does paid work, consultancy or holds business interests in the same field, or with organisations that work with or compete with us.
- Sits on the board of, or advises, another organisation that seeks funding from or partnership with us, or that funds us.
- Knows a candidate they are interviewing, or a participant they are selecting for a programme or grant.
- Is offered a personal benefit by someone who has, or wants, a relationship with Lead Now Foundation.

3.3 How to declare

1. Complete the Declaration of Interests form (Appendix A) within one month of joining Lead Now Foundation, and every year after that.
2. The duty to declare is ongoing. If a new interest arises during the year, update your declaration straight away — and always before taking part in a related decision.
3. At the start of any decision-making meeting (for example, a procurement, recruitment or grant decision), anyone with a conflict declares it, and the declaration is recorded in the minutes.

Directors also make the disclosures of interest required by the Companies Act, 2013 at the first Board meeting of each financial year and whenever their interests change. Transactions with directors or their relatives require Board approval under the Act.

3.4 Who reviews a declaration

Declaration made by	Reviewed by
Staff, volunteers, interns and consultants	CEO
CEO	Chair of the Board
Directors (including the Chair)	The Board, with the director concerned taking no part

The reviewer decides whether there is a real, potential or perceived conflict, considering:

- Would our funders, partners or the communities we work with be concerned?
- Could it affect our ability to follow our policies and procedures consistently?
- Could it damage our reputation, or the wider case for youth-led development?
- Does it conflict with our values?
- Could it lead — or appear to lead — to fraud, a breach of financial policy, or poor value for money?

The reviewer then sets out the action needed, which will either remove the conflict entirely (for example, the person steps aside from the decision, gives up the interest, or changes reporting lines) or manage it transparently, so that others are aware and no improper perception can arise. The outcome is recorded.

3.5 Register of interests

The Finance & Admin Officer keeps a confidential register of all declarations and outcomes, on behalf of the CEO. Declarations by the CEO and directors are held by the Chair of the Board, and included in the register. The register is shared with the statutory auditor on request.

4. Fraud and Irregularities

Policy

Lead Now Foundation has zero tolerance for fraud. Any proven fraud by a staff member will result in dismissal. We will use every lawful means to recover lost funds, and will report fraud to the police and to affected funders and partners.

4.1 Examples of fraud

The following list is not exhaustive:

- Claiming for work not performed, or for false or inflated travel, expense or allowance claims.
- Submitting petty cash vouchers or receipts where no spending took place, or altering receipts.
- Creating or inflating participant, attendance or beneficiary lists to justify spending.
- Paying allowances to people who did not receive them, or keeping part of an allowance.
- Adding fictitious staff or suppliers to the payroll or supplier list.
- Selecting friends or relatives as suppliers, partners or staff without following proper procedures, or accepting kickbacks.
- Diverting donations or other income, or misappropriating assets.
- Changing a supplier's or employee's bank details to redirect payments.
- Misreporting results or spending to funders.

4.2 Other irregularities

Irregularities include unauthorised use of resources for private gain, such as "borrowing" from petty cash, personal use of vehicles, or misuse of phones, laptops and other equipment. They will be dealt with through the disciplinary procedure and may be treated as fraud.

4.3 Fraud against us from outside

Fraud can also come from outside — for example, fake invoices, emails impersonating a supplier or senior colleague asking for urgent payment or a change of bank details, or online banking scams. Always verify unusual payment requests by phone using a number you already hold, never one given in the request. Report any attempt to the Finance & Admin Officer.

5. Bribery and Corruption

Policy

Lead Now Foundation has zero tolerance for bribery and corruption. No one may offer, give, request or accept a bribe, in any form, directly or through anyone else — whether to or from a public official or anyone in the private or non-profit sector.

We seek to work only with partners, suppliers and funders who share this approach.

We will never expect anyone to risk their life, safety or freedom to uphold this policy (Section 5.6).

5.1 The law

In India, bribery and corruption are prohibited mainly by the **Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988**, as amended in 2018. It makes it an offence to give, promise or accept an undue advantage in connection with a public servant's duties, including through a third party. The Act also recognises that an organisation can show it had adequate procedures in place to prevent bribery by people acting on its behalf. This policy, and the controls in our Finance Policy and Procedures, are those procedures.

Fraud, cheating, forgery and criminal breach of trust are offences under the **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023**, and fraud by people connected with a company is also an offence under the **Companies Act, 2013**.

5.2 Examples of bribery

- Offering a funder's staff a gift or lavish hospitality in return for approving a grant.
- A potential supplier offering money, a gift or a "commission" to influence a procurement decision.
- Paying an official to speed up a registration, licence, permission or clearance.
- A job applicant, or a young person's family, offering money or favours to secure a place, a job or a grant.
- Paying a "fee" to a local official or gatekeeper to allow a programme to go ahead.

5.3 Facilitation payments

Facilitation payments are bribes, however small or customary, and are prohibited. They do not include official fees set by law and receipted by the relevant authority, or legitimate fast-track services offered openly at a published price. If you are unsure whether a fee is legitimate, ask for an official receipt and consult the CEO before paying.

5.4 Gifts and hospitality

Small, proportionate gifts and hospitality that build good relationships are a normal part of working life, and are unlikely to be bribes. But extravagant gifts and hospitality can be used to disguise bribes or create a sense of obligation, and can present a conflict of interest.

Policy

Never offer or accept a gift or hospitality that could influence — or appear to influence — a decision, especially during a procurement, recruitment, grant or funding process.

Never offer or accept gifts of cash, vouchers or anything easily converted to cash.

Never give gifts or hospitality to public officials beyond modest, customary courtesies such as tea or a working meal.

Value of gift or hospitality offered to you	What to do
Under ₹1,000 (for example, a diary, sweets during a festival, a working meal)	May be accepted. No need to declare.
₹1,000 to ₹5,000	Declare it in the Gifts and Hospitality Register (Appendix B) within five working days. The CEO decides whether it may be kept, shared with the team, or returned.
Over ₹5,000, or any amount from someone in an active procurement, recruitment or grant process	Politely decline. If it cannot be declined without causing offence, accept it on behalf of Lead Now Foundation, declare it, and hand it to the CEO.

Gifts and hospitality offered by Lead Now Foundation (for example, tokens of appreciation for speakers or partners) must be modest, approved in advance by the budget holder, and recorded. Gifts to the CEO are declared to the Chair of the Board.

5.5 Political and charitable donations

- Lead Now Foundation is non-partisan. It makes no donations, in cash or in kind, to political parties, politicians or political campaigns.
- Any donation or grant made or received by Lead Now Foundation must not be an inducement to act improperly, and must be approved in line with our procedures.
- We may engage constructively with policymakers and government, as our mission requires — but never by offering any personal advantage.

5.6 When your safety is at risk

If you are threatened with violence, detention or other serious harm unless you pay, your safety comes first. Pay only what is needed to remove the threat, and leave as soon as it is safe. Report the incident to your Performance Manager or the CEO as soon as possible, recording what was paid, to whom and why. Payments made under duress are not a breach of this policy, but they

must be reported and recorded transparently. Managers must plan programmes and travel to reduce the risk of such demands.

6. Roles and Responsibilities

Everyone at Lead Now Foundation is expected to play an active part in preventing fraud and bribery, and in improving how we do it.

Who	Responsibilities
Board of Directors	Provides leadership and resources for this policy, approves it and any changes, and makes sure it is fit for purpose and followed. Receives a quarterly report of incidents, and is informed immediately of any material incident.
Chair of the Board	Reviews the CEO's declarations of interest and gifts. Receives and oversees any concern involving the CEO.
CEO	Leads our anti-fraud and anti-bribery culture visibly. Makes sure this policy is implemented consistently, risks are assessed, incidents are investigated and reported, and auditors' recommendations on fraud and bribery are acted on. Reviews staff declarations of interest.
Program Lead	Assesses fraud and bribery risks in programmes, partnerships and grants; holds programme staff and partners to account; monitors the confidential reporting inbox and escalates concerns appropriately.
Finance & Admin Officer	Builds the spirit of this policy into all financial processes, including accounting for gifts, expenses and donations; maintains the registers of interests, gifts and incidents; supplies information to auditors.
Anyone managing people or recruitment	Makes sure this policy is reflected in recruitment, induction, training, performance management and reward.
Anyone fundraising	Makes sure our relationships with funders are free of any improper inducement, in either direction.
Staff and young leaders	Never give or receive bribes; declare interests and gifts; challenge and report any fraud, bribery or irregularity they become aware of; record all financial transactions in line with the Finance Policy and Procedures.

Who	Responsibilities
Volunteers	Use any funds they receive — whether allowances or funds for activities — and their own funds while volunteering, appropriately; sign and follow the Code of Conduct. A volunteer who breaches this policy will be asked to leave the programme.

Anyone who fails to meet these responsibilities will face disciplinary action, up to and including dismissal, with the usual right of appeal.

7. Prevention

7.1 Leadership from the top

The Board and CEO are committed to tackling fraud and bribery at the highest level, and to modelling the behaviour this policy requires. The disciplinary consequences of fraud and bribery are set out in Section 6 of the Human Resource Manual.

7.2 Risk assessment

The CEO, Program Lead and Finance & Admin Officer assess the risks of fraud and bribery in specific programmes, partnerships, grants, funder relationships and supplier relationships, and record significant risks and their mitigations in the organisational risk register. The register is reviewed by the CEO quarterly and by the Board at least twice a year.

7.3 Due diligence

People

Good practice starts before someone joins us. Safe and fair recruitment (Human Resource Manual, Section 3.4), reference checks, the Code of Conduct and induction training help us build a team grounded in integrity.

Suppliers, partners and grantees

Anyone engaging suppliers, partners or grantees on behalf of Lead Now Foundation must make sure that:

- They are selected through a transparent and competitive process (Finance Policy and Procedures, Sections 6 and 7).
- Due diligence proportionate to the risk is completed before any agreement is signed.
- They are briefed, where practical, on this policy and their responsibilities under it.
- Every contract and grant agreement prohibits giving or receiving bribes on Lead Now Foundation's behalf, requires conflicts of interest to be declared, gives us the right to review relevant records, and allows us to end the agreement if these terms are breached.

Funders

The CEO checks that significant new funders are reputable, and that accepting their funds would not compromise our independence or integrity (Finance Policy and Procedures, Section 4.4).

7.4 Controls that prevent fraud

Control	Where to find it
Segregation of duties, authorisation limits and two-person payment approval	Finance Policy and Procedures, Section 2
Procurement process and Procurement Committee	Finance Policy and Procedures, Section 6
Cash limits, floats, allowance registers and spot checks	Finance Policy and Procedures, Section 5
Monthly bank and cash reconciliations reviewed by the CEO	Finance Policy and Procedures, Section 10
Fixed asset register and annual asset counts	Finance Policy and Procedures, Section 8
Annual statutory audit and auditor's management letter	Finance Policy and Procedures, Section 15
Safe recruitment and Code of Conduct	Human Resource Manual, Section 3
Confidential whistleblowing route	Human Resource Manual, Section 9
Registers of interests, gifts and incidents	This policy, Sections 3.5, 5.4 and 9.3

In addition, the CEO arranges a periodic internal review of financial controls — by someone independent of day-to-day finance, such as a Board member with financial expertise or an external accountant — at least once a year.

7.5 Communication and training

- All staff and volunteers are briefed on this policy at induction, and sign to confirm they have read and will follow it (Appendix D).
- All staff receive training on fraud, bribery, conflicts of interest and our financial controls at least once a year.
- Partners and suppliers are briefed on this policy where practical, and bound by it through their agreements.
- This policy is published on our website.

8. Reporting Concerns

Policy

Everyone covered by this policy must report any suspected fraud, bribery, corruption, irregularity or undeclared conflict of interest as soon as they become aware of it. Do not investigate it yourself, confront the person involved, or discuss it with others.

8.1 If you are offered or asked for a bribe

- Refuse, and make Lead Now Foundation's position clear. It can help to say that our policy forbids it and that every payment must be receipted.
- Record the details — who, what, when, where and any witnesses — as soon as possible afterwards.
- Report it the same day to your Performance Manager or the CEO.

8.2 How to report

Route	When to use it
Your Performance Manager	The usual first step — verbally, then in writing.
The CEO	If you cannot raise it with your Performance Manager, or they may be involved.
info@leadnowfoundation.org (monitored by the Program Lead)	If you want to raise it confidentially, outside your reporting line. The Program Lead escalates it to the CEO, or to the Board Chair if the CEO is involved.
Chair of the Board of Directors	If the concern involves the CEO.

Managers who receive a report must pass it to the CEO immediately (or to the Board Chair if the CEO is involved). The CEO informs the Board Chair of every suspected fraud or bribery incident, whatever its value. Partners, suppliers and members of the public may also report concerns to info@leadnowfoundation.org. The full whistleblowing procedure, including how confidentiality is protected, is in Section 9 of the Human Resource Manual.

8.3 Protection for people who report

Lead Now Foundation will protect anyone who reports a concern in good faith from any negative consequences, even if the concern turns out to be mistaken. As far as possible without affecting the investigation, the identity of the person reporting will be kept confidential. Anyone who victimises or retaliates against a person who has reported a concern will face disciplinary action. Deliberately false or malicious reports will also be treated as a disciplinary matter.

8.4 Matters that do not need reporting

Genuine errors that are picked up by our normal controls before a payment is made do not usually need to be reported under this policy. However, persistent problems — such as repeated misunderstanding of a procedure — should be reported, so that the procedure can be made clearer.

9. Responding to Incidents

Even with strong controls and a values-led culture, the nature of our work means some fraud or attempted fraud is likely to occur at some point, inside or outside the organisation. Every incident is different, and our response will depend on the facts. Three principles always apply.

Principle	What it means
Zero tolerance	Any staff member found to have committed fraud or bribery will be dismissed. Partners and suppliers found to have done so will have their agreements ended.
Learning from experience	Every incident is reported to the CEO and Board Chair, whatever its value, and we change our systems to prevent it happening again.
Transparency	We do not hide incidents from staff, the Board, funders or regulators. We communicate with sensitivity, and share the steps taken to prevent a recurrence.

9.1 Our response, step by step

If the CEO is involved, the Chair of the Board leads each step below in place of the CEO, and may appoint an independent investigator.

Step	What happens
1. Report	The concern is reported in line with Section 8, and the CEO informs the Board Chair.
2. Secure	The CEO takes immediate steps to prevent further loss and preserve evidence — for example, suspending payments, changing passwords or bank access, and securing records. Evidence must not be altered or destroyed.
3. Plan	The CEO, with the Board Chair, decides whether an investigation is needed and agrees an investigation plan: who will investigate, the scope and the timeline. Investigators must be independent of the matter. External specialists may be engaged.
4. Investigate	The investigation follows the disciplinary procedure in Section 6 of the Human Resource Manual. If there is a reasonable risk of further harm, the person concerned may be suspended on full pay; this is not a finding of guilt. Everyone is presumed innocent until the facts are established, and investigations are conducted sensitively and promptly.

Step	What happens
5. Decide and act	Where fraud or bribery is confirmed, the staff member is dismissed and the matter is reported to the police. Partners' or suppliers' agreements are ended. Where the evidence is not conclusive, other disciplinary or corrective action may still be taken.
6. Recover	We pursue every lawful means to recover losses — through the bank, insurance, recovery from the person responsible, or legal action — and adjust budgets and forecasts as needed.
7. Communicate	Relevant staff are informed of the outcome, with due regard to confidentiality. An Incident Report (Appendix C) is completed and shared with the Board. Confirmed incidents are reported to affected funders, in line with our agreements with them, and to regulators where required.
8. Learn	The CEO and Board review what happened, why our controls did not prevent it, and what will change. Agreed changes are made to our policies and procedures and shared with staff.

9.2 Legal and regulatory reporting

Depending on the facts, we may need to report an incident to the police, to funders under our agreements, or to regulators. The statutory auditor also has duties under the Companies Act, 2013 to report certain frauds they identify. The CEO, with the Board Chair, will seek advice from our Chartered Accountant or a lawyer on what must be reported and to whom.

9.3 Incident register

The Finance & Admin Officer maintains a confidential register of every suspected and confirmed incident, on behalf of the CEO, recording what happened, the action taken and the outcome. (Incidents involving the Finance & Admin Officer are recorded by the CEO; incidents involving the CEO by the Board Chair.) A summary is reported to the Board quarterly, and any material incident is reported to the Board immediately.

10. Monitoring and Review

This policy is approved by the Board of Directors. It will be reviewed every year, and after any significant change in our operations or any significant incident, in consultation with staff. The Board will consider the registers of interests, gifts and incidents as part of each review.

Appendix A: Declaration of Interests

Complete within one month of joining, every year, and whenever your interests change. If in doubt, declare (Section 3).

Name and role	
Date	

Type of interest	Details (name of person or organisation, and nature of interest)
Close family members working for or with Lead Now Foundation	
Interests in suppliers, partners, grantees or funders (yours or your close family's)	
Other paid work, consultancy or business interests	
Board, trustee or advisory roles in other organisations	
Political or public roles	
Any other interest that could be relevant	

☐ I have no interests to declare.	
I confirm this declaration is complete and accurate, and I will update it if my interests change.	
Signature and date	

For the reviewer	
Conflict identified?	☐ None ☐ Perceived ☐ Potential ☐ Real
Action agreed	
Reviewed by (name, role), signature and date	

Appendix B: Gifts and Hospitality Register

Record every gift or hospitality worth ₹1,000 or more offered to, or given by, anyone acting for Lead Now Foundation — whether accepted or declined (Section 5.4).

Date	Offered to / by	From / to (organisation)	Description	Value (₹)	Accepted / declined	CEO decision

Appendix C: Fraud and Bribery Incident Report

Completed by the CEO (or the Board Chair, if the CEO is involved) and shared with the Board. Keep confidential.

Incident	
Reference number	
Date reported, and by whom	
Date(s) of the incident	
Type	☐ Fraud ☐ Bribery ☐ Irregularity ☐ Conflict of interest ☐ External fraud attempt
Description of what happened	
Funds or assets involved (₹) and funding source	
Response	
Immediate steps taken to prevent further loss	
Investigation (who, scope, dates)	
Findings	
Action taken (disciplinary, police, contract ended, recovery)	
Funders, regulators or police notified (who and when)	
Learning	
What allowed this to happen?	
Changes agreed to policies, controls or training	
Completed by (name, role), signature and date	

Appendix D: Acknowledgement

To be signed by everyone covered by this policy at induction, and kept on their personnel or volunteer file.

1. I have read and understood Lead Now Foundation's Fraud, Bribery and Conflict of Interest Policy.
2. I will never offer, give, request or accept a bribe, and I will report any bribe I am offered or asked for.
3. I will declare my interests, and any gifts or hospitality, as this policy requires.
4. I will report any fraud, bribery, irregularity or conflict of interest I become aware of.
5. I will follow Lead Now Foundation's values and policies, and do my best to serve young people with the rest of the Lead Now team.
6. I understand that failing to follow this policy may lead to disciplinary action, including dismissal, and to legal action.

Name	
Role	
Signature	
Date	

Approval

This Fraud, Bribery and Conflict of Interest Policy was approved by the Board of Directors of Lead Now Foundation and comes into effect on the date below. It will be reviewed annually, or sooner after a significant change or incident.

_____

Chair, Board of Directors

Name: _____ Date: _____

_____

Chief Executive Officer

Name: _____ Date: _____

Building Leaders. Transforming Communities.